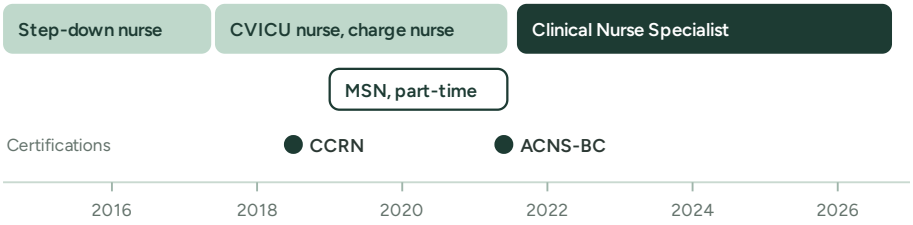
Amara Okonkwo

Clinical Nurse Specialist, Cardiovascular Critical Care

MSN, RN, ACNS-BC, CCRN

> Cardiovascular ICU clinical nurse specialist with 12 years at the bedside and in practice leadership. I work between the unit and the evidence: turning protocols into habits that bedside nurses keep, then measuring whether outcomes moved. Strongest in recovery after cardiac surgery, mechanical circulatory support and bringing new nurses into the ICU.

Career at a glance



Experience

Aug 2021 – Present
Clinical Nurse Specialist, Cardiovascular ICU
St. Aldric Medical Center, Houston, TX

- Practice lead for a 32-bed CVICU with 140 nurses; chair of the unit practice council.
- Introduced an early-mobility pathway after cardiac surgery: **ICU stay down 0.7 days** and ventilator days down 18% in 12 months.
- Redesigned the central-line care bundle with infection prevention; the unit has gone **14 months without a CLABSI**.
- Built an eight-week preceptor programme for new ICU nurses; first-year RN retention rose from 78% to 89%.

Jun 2017 – Jul 2021
Charge Nurse and Staff RN, Cardiovascular ICU
St. Aldric Medical Center, Houston, TX

- Cared for patients after CABG, valve surgery and TAVR, and on ECMO, IABP and Impella support.
- Charge nurse on nights and weekends; precepted more than 20 new graduates.
- Super-user for the 2019 EHR upgrade, training 60 colleagues on the unit.

Jul 2014 – May 2017
Staff Nurse, Cardiac Step-Down
Bayview Community Hospital, Galveston, TX

- Telemetry and post-procedure care on a 28-bed cardiac unit; resource nurse for new graduates.
- Led the unit's falls-prevention audit; falls with injury dropped from five to two the following year.

AO

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Location
Houston, Texas

Licence
Registered Nurse, Texas

Core strengths

- Hemodynamic monitoring and titration
- Mechanical circulatory support: ECMO, IABP, Impella
- Recovery pathways after cardiac surgery
- Evidence-based practice and quality improvement
- Preceptorship and clinical education
- Nurse-driven protocols and EHR optimisation

Certifications

CCRN — Adult Critical Care
Certified 2018, renewed 2024

ACNS-BC — Adult-Gerontology CNS
Certified 2021

ACLS BLS — Life support
Current, expire 2027

Languages

English	Native
Igbo	Fluent
Spanish	Conversational

Education

2019
2021

MSN, Adult-Gerontology Clinical Nurse Specialist
Gulf Coast University School of Nursing, part-time

2010
2014

BSN, Nursing
Gulf Coast University School of Nursing, graduated with honours

Quality improvement projects

2024

Preceptor Academy
Eight weeks of simulation-based training for ICU preceptors; 46 nurses through the programme so far.
First-year RN retention up from 78% to 89%.

2023

Early mobility after cardiac surgery
Six-month pilot on one pod, then rolled out unit-wide with daily mobility goals set at bedside rounds.
ICU stay down 0.7 days; ventilator days down 18%.

2022

Central-line bundle redesign
Daily line-necessity review and a standard dressing kit, built with infection prevention.
14 months without a CLABSI and counting.

2021

Delirium screening protocol
Delirium screening every shift for post-surgical patients, with nurse-led escalation criteria agreed with the cardiac surgery team.
Delirium identified a median 1.4 days earlier.

Teaching and presentations

- **Clinical adjunct faculty**, Gulf Coast University School of Nursing, 2022 to present: critical-care module for 60 BSN students a year.
- **Poster**, Regional Critical Care Symposium, 2024: early mobility after cardiac surgery.
- **Co-author**, Journal of Cardiovascular Nursing Practice, 2023: standardising CLABSI prevention bundles in a cardiac ICU.

References

Daniela Ruiz, DNP, RN
Director of Critical Care Services
St. Aldric Medical Center

Dr. Peter Lindahl
Medical Director, Cardiovascular ICU
St. Aldric Medical Center

Contact details available on request.

Contact

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Clinical skills

- Arterial and central line management
- Swan-Ganz catheter monitoring
- CRRT and targeted temperature management
- Chest tube and temporary pacing care
- Epic and Cerner documentation

Memberships

American Association of Critical-Care Nurses
Member since 2015

National Association of Clinical Nurse Specialists
Member since 2021

Awards

Nurse Excellence Award
St. Aldric Medical Center, 2023

Preceptor of the Year
St. Aldric Medical Center, 2020

Continuing education

Evidence-based practice fellowship
Nursing Research Council, 2024

Clinical leadership programme
2025

Advanced hemodynamics workshop
2023

Impella heart pump specialist course
2022